

Overdrawing on Experience: Panpsychism and the Limits of First-Person Warrant

Abstract

Panpsychism is often motivated by an appeal to the epistemic privilege of consciousness. Physical science seems to describe matter in structural, relational, dispositional, or dynamic terms, while consciousness is known directly from the first-person point of view. This paper argues that this appeal supports less than panpsychism requires. First-person experience establishes consciousness as a datum and shows that the experiences with which we are acquainted have determinate phenomenal character. It does not, by itself, disclose bare metaphysical subjectivity, micro-experience, proto-experience, cosmic subjectivity, hidden phenomenal fields, or relations of phenomenal inheritance. Those posits may still be defended, but they must be defended as theoretical posits and judged by their explanatory work. The argument does not derive consciousness from organization. Rather, it asks what explanatory work remains for a hidden phenomenal base once organization explains the structure of ordinary consciousness. The conclusion is not that panpsychism is false. It is that panpsychism forfeits the special authority of first-person evidence once it moves beyond ordinary consciousness into hidden phenomenal ontology.

Keywords: panpsychism, consciousness, first-person warrant, Russellian monism, cosmopsychism, introspection

1 Introduction: Panpsychism's Appeal

Panpsychism derives much of its contemporary appeal from an epistemic asymmetry. Consciousness, unlike many entities posited by physical science, is known from the first-person point of view. When I am in pain, I do not posit the pain as I posit an electron or a gene. The pain is given. Physical science, by contrast, is often taken to describe matter in structural, relational, and dispositional terms. It tells us what matter does, but not, at least on one influential line of thought, what matter is intrinsically. If consciousness is the one reality known from the inside, then perhaps consciousness, or something consciousness-like, belongs in our account of fundamental reality. This thought gives panpsychism its distinctive force. It promises to avoid the apparent emergence of consciousness from an entirely non-conscious base by locating mentality, proto-mentality, or phenomenal character in the nature of matter itself. In

its more sophisticated forms, the view is not the simple claim that electrons have recognizably human-like minds. Strawson's realistic monism, for example, argues that a serious physicalism must take experience as part of the physical world and cannot treat experiential reality as an inexplicable late arrival (Strawson 2006). Goff's Russellian monist defense places panpsychism in a broader argument about the categorical nature of matter and the limits of structural physics (Goff 2017a).

The appeal to first-person experience also imposes a constraint. If first-person experience is the source of panpsychism's special warrant, then the view may claim that warrant only for what first-person experience actually discloses. Three questions need to be kept apart here: whether conscious experience exists, what features it has, and what its metaphysical status is. First-person experience answers the first robustly. It bears on the second more cautiously, since our grasp of phenomenal character may be partial and fallible. It does not by itself answer the third, which asks whether consciousness is fundamental, intrinsic, derivative, organizational, microphysical, or cosmic.

Panpsychism often overdraws on the evidential authority of first-person experience. The datum supplied by experience is real but finite, and panpsychism repeatedly draws against it for posits the datum cannot cover. The argument targets that warrant, while leaving broader defenses of panpsychism, hidden entities, and nonstructural explanations of consciousness available as theoretical options. Its claim is narrower: first-person experience supplies panpsychism with a datum, not with the metaphysical conclusion panpsychism wants to draw from it. It establishes that consciousness exists and discloses certain features of ordinary conscious life. It does not establish that consciousness is fundamental, ubiquitous, microphysical, cosmic, or hidden in the categorical basis of physical structure. Even pure-awareness cases, sometimes treated as the purest first-person evidence, depend when used as public evidence on reports, memory, temporal location, and a standpoint from which the episode can later be described.

2 Scope and Bracketing

The scope is limited. Panpsychists may appeal to the alleged impossibility of radical emergence, to continuity in nature, to theoretical simplicity, to dissatisfaction with standard physicalism, or to the explanatory gap. They may also defend a Russellian monist thesis according to which physics describes only structure and dynamics, leaving the intrinsic nature of matter unspecified. Those arguments raise large issues that cannot be settled here.

My target is narrower. I am concerned with one prominent motivation for panpsychism: the claim that consciousness has a special epistemic status because it is known directly from within. This motivation matters because it gives panpsychism a distinctive rhetorical and philosophical force. The panpsychist appears to begin from the one thing we know most intimately, namely experience itself.

That route is legitimate as far as it goes. Its reach is limited. First-person experience may establish the reality of consciousness. It may also disclose features

of conscious life that any adequate theory should respect. It does not automatically support claims about the distribution, fundamentality, or cosmic structure of consciousness.

This scope restriction is important because a panpsychist could otherwise object that the paper confuses two questions. One question is whether consciousness exists and is known in a distinctive first-person way. A second question is whether consciousness, or something related to it, belongs to the fundamental nature of matter. The first question can be answered from the first-person point of view. The second cannot. It requires a metaphysical argument.

I bracket the full case for Russellian monism, but I take up one step within it: the move from the claim that physics gives only structure and dynamics to the claim that the categorical basis of structure is phenomenal. Even if physics gives only structure and dynamics, it does not follow that the categorical nature behind that structure is phenomenal or proto-phenomenal. The structure/dynamics argument may create a vacancy. It does not show that consciousness fills it.

A panpsychist may reply that no one serious claims first-person experience alone proves panpsychism. The better argument is abductive: consciousness is known directly, physics gives only structure, radical emergence looks suspect, and panpsychism is therefore offered as the best metaphysical hypothesis. I grant that this is the stronger version of the view. The warrant problem remains. The abduction quietly treats the first-person datum as the right kind of thing to fill the gap that physics leaves. That fittingness assumption, that experience is the type of categorical filler the structure-and-dynamics argument calls for, is itself a metaphysical claim about the datum and not something the datum delivers on its own. What we know from within is organized, temporal experience with phenomenal character, anchored in a body and a history. Whether that experience reveals intrinsic, categorical, or fundamental nature is precisely what needs argument. Once that distinction is made explicit, panpsychism may remain a legitimate metaphysical theory while forfeiting the special authority of first-person evidence. Its micro-, proto-, and cosmic-phenomenal posits then have to be judged by what they explain and what they cost.

The worry reaches careful formulations as well as careless ones. Strawson explicitly treats experience as “the fundamental given natural fact” and as an obligatory starting point for any realistic theory of what exists (Strawson 2006, 4). Goff’s case against physicalism includes a Revelation thesis, roughly, that the nature of our conscious states is introspectively revealed to us (Goff 2017a, 106–132). These are careful philosophers, and neither should be read as making a crude inference from pain to conscious electrons. Still, their arguments gain force from the thought that experience enjoys an epistemic standing unlike that of ordinary theoretical posits. The issue is how far that standing can legitimately travel.

The paper is therefore adjacent to, but not a substitute for, the recent literature on the combination problem and constitutive panpsychism, much of which is organized around the terrain mapped in Brüntrup and Jaskolla (2017). Chalmers distinguishes panpsychism from panprotopsyism and formulates the combination problem as a central obstacle for views that derive macro-consciousness from micro-level phenomenal or proto-phenomenal facts (Chalmers 2015, 2017). Coleman presses

the subject-summing problem against micropsychist combination (Coleman 2014). Mørch argues that dispositionalism about properties supports a phenomenal-powers panpsychism, and develops the broader phenomenal-powers metaphysics elsewhere, while Roelofs defends the coherence of composite subjectivity against several anti-combination arguments (Mørch 2020, forthcoming; Roelofs 2019). Those debates ask whether panpsychism can make good on its internal explanatory obligations. My question is prior in the order of warrant: when these views introduce micro-experience, proto-phenomenal powers, phenomenal bonding, composite subjects, or cosmic subjectivity, what part of their support comes from first-person evidence, and what part must be earned as theory?

Two recent papers make this adjacency especially close. Roelofs argues that constitutive panpsychists can accept a medium-strength revelation thesis without being committed to every constitutive fact about consciousness appearing transparently in introspection (Roelofs 2020). Lin presses the more hostile conclusion that revelation cannot favor panpsychism over physicalism, since Chalmers’s distinction between the essence of phenomenal properties and their grounds either fails to rescue panpsychism or can be used by physicalists as well (Lin 2025). That debate runs along one axis, whether revelation can do work in favor of panpsychism. The question taken up here runs along another: even when first-person acquaintance is treated as the source of panpsychism’s special evidence, what exactly does that acquaintance disclose, and what part of panpsychism’s hidden ontology must be earned as theory rather than carried over from the datum?

There is also at least one explicit first-person route to panpsychism. Ramm defends panpsychist idealism by beginning from the first-person perspective and using phenomenological reflection to motivate a broader idealist-panpsychist picture (Ramm 2021). That argument gives the worry a named target: first-person evidence is being asked to do metaphysical work. My objection is that such work must be carefully limited. First-person reflection may disclose ordinary experience, but it does not by itself disclose the hidden phenomenal structure of the world.

3 The Introspective Warrant Constraint

Panpsychism often draws force from a claim about the special epistemic status of consciousness. Consciousness is not known in the way electrons, genes, or black holes are known. I do not posit my current pain as a theoretical entity. I undergo it. Conscious experience is given from the first-person point of view.

This appeal is legitimate, but it must be disciplined. Direct knowledge of consciousness gives warrant for what is actually given in experience. It does not give every entity described as phenomenal, proto-phenomenal, or experiential the same standing. First-person warrant is not a transferable credit.

Call this the introspective warrant constraint:

A theory that motivates itself by appeal to first-person experience may claim first-person warrant only for what first-person experience actually discloses.

The constraint is modest. It allows theoretical posits. Physics, biology, and psychology all legitimately posit entities and structures not given in ordinary experience.

But those posits are warranted by explanatory, predictive, or unificatory work. They do not inherit the authority of first-person acquaintance. If panpsychism posits micro-experience, proto-experience, cosmic subjectivity, hidden phenomenal fields, or relations of phenomenal inheritance, those posits may be defended as theoretical entities. They may not be treated as if they were directly warranted by the first-person datum of consciousness.

The datum is modest: consciousness exists. There is something it is like to undergo pain, see red, hear a sound, remember a face, or feel time passing. The characterization of the datum is also modest: the experiences with which we are acquainted have phenomenal character. This claim does not require that phenomenal character be sharp, stable, or fully articulable. A mood may be vague, peripheral vision indeterminate, and anticipation foggy. These are still ways experience is given. Vagueness and foggy-ness are themselves phenomenal characters, not routes to a subjectivity without any phenomenal character at all. The characterization is therefore compatible with hard cases, including minimal experience, meditative states, moods, objectless anxiety, reports of dreamless sleep, and claims about pure consciousness. Those cases can be granted. The point is only that acquaintance does not present consciousness as bare metaphysical subjectivity without any phenomenal character at all. Metaphysical inflation begins when consciousness, proto-consciousness, or subjectivity is said to belong to the fundamental nature of matter, to exist at the microphysical level, or to characterize the universe as a whole.

The introspective warrant constraint allows the first step. It also allows the second. But it blocks any automatic passage to the third. First-person experience warrants the existence of ordinary consciousness and discloses something about its character. It does not by itself disclose consciousness as belonging to the fundamental level as such, to the microphysical level in particular, or to the categorical basis of physical reality.

This constraint matters because panpsychism often presents itself as unusually faithful to consciousness. Its promise is to take experience seriously rather than explaining it away. But taking experience seriously also means taking seriously the limits of what experience gives. First-person experience gives us conscious life with some determinate phenomenal character. It does not give us bare subjectivity detached from all character, nor micro-experiences hidden in particles, nor proto-experiential categorical properties, nor a unified cosmic experienter.

4 What First-Person Experience Discloses

The first-person datum is sometimes described as bare subjectivity, pure awareness, or mere what-it-is-likeness. That description is tempting because it seems to isolate the minimal feature common to all conscious states. Yet it risks abstracting away precisely the features that make consciousness intelligible as a datum.

When we attend to consciousness, we do not find subjectivity as an empty item standing apart from all character. In ordinary waking cases, we find sensation, mood, thought, temporal flow, embodiment, and varying degrees of attention. Less ordinary cases should be treated with care. A meditative state, an objectless mood, or a claimed pure-consciousness state may lack many features of ordinary experience. But insofar

as it is available to first-person acquaintance, it is available as something: calm, blank, diffuse, silent, contentless, expansive, or otherwise phenomenally determinate. The relevant point is not that every conscious state represents an external object. It is that the experiences we can appeal to as evidence are never given as bare metaphysical subjectivity.

Appeals to fundamental subjectivity now face a question. Does the posited fundamental consciousness have phenomenal character, or not? If it does, then it already has structure that calls for explanation, and cannot be the simple primitive known by introspection alone. If it does not, then it is not something first-person experience discloses at all, but an abstraction from experience rather than an item found in it.

The dilemma is especially important for views that retreat from rich consciousness to minimal subjectivity. The move is understandable. Few panpsychists want to say that electrons have visual fields, memories, anxieties, or personal identities. So the relevant posit is often thinned out. The fundamental level is said to contain minimal phenomenal character, bare subjectivity, or proto-experiential nature. But thinning the posit changes its epistemic status. The thinner it becomes, the less it resembles the consciousness that first-person experience actually gives. Thinning also does not escape the first horn of the dilemma. Whatever phenomenal character is retained, however minimal, is character of some determinate sort; structure does not vanish by being made small. A posit with minimal phenomenal character still has phenomenal character, and that character still demands the kind of explanation the dilemma required.

Minimal subjectivity may be coherent. It still cannot simply borrow the warrant of ordinary experience. The familiar datum is structured consciousness. A stripped-down subjectivity with no content, valence, temporality, or structure is not given in the same way. If it is introduced, it is introduced by theory.

This point overlaps with Frankish's worry about the depsychologization of consciousness in panpsychist contexts (Frankish 2021). The more consciousness is stripped of the psychological roles by which we ordinarily recognize it, the less clear it becomes that the retained posit is still the consciousness from which the argument began. I do not rely on an illusionist conclusion. The more modest point is enough: a depsychologized or contentless posit may be a coherent theoretical posit. It is not simply the first-person datum under another name.

4.1 The Reportability Constraint

The strongest challenge here comes from meditators who report pure or contentless awareness. They describe moments of consciousness without any object, self, or thought, which is exactly the kind of bare subjectivity the previous section denied was given in experience. Metzinger develops minimal phenomenal experience as a candidate for the simplest form of consciousness, drawing on meditative reports of pure awareness and tonic alertness (Metzinger 2020). Gamma and Metzinger's questionnaire study extends this project empirically by using reports from meditators to profile minimal phenomenal experience (Gamma and Metzinger 2021). Philosophical treatments of witness-consciousness and pure awareness likewise suggest that awareness

may be present without ordinary object-directed content, self-identification, or discursive thought (Albahari 2006, 2009; Thompson 2014). Meditation-induced cessations raise a related but distinct issue. They are often described as interruptions, absences, or border cases of consciousness. Still, they make the evidential problem especially vivid: what reaches the philosophical discussion is always a report of an episode in which ordinary consciousness was said to be absent (Laukkonen et al. 2023).

These cases should be granted for the sake of argument. The present paper need not deny that there are minimal, nondual, selfless, or apparently contentless states. It need not decide whether *nirodha samapatti* is best described as consciousness without content, absence of consciousness, or a remembered transition around an absence. When such states function as public philosophical evidence, they reach the theorist through report, memory, interpretation, and later classification. A panpsychist might say that private acquaintance with pure awareness need not be report-mediated. But then the original dilemma returns: either the state is privately given with some phenomenal character, however attenuated, or it is not disclosed as experience in the relevant first-person sense.

A reportable episode must be available later as something that occurred. It must be retained or reconstructed in memory and attributed in some way to the subject who reports it. Lin makes the point sharper for selfless states. If a state is supposed to be wholly selfless, it is hard to see how an autobiographical memory of it can establish what it was like (Lin 2022).

The same form of pressure applies to contentless-awareness reports when they are taken to establish the absence of phenomenal structure. Zahavi argues that experiential subjectivity cannot be cleanly detached from a minimal *for-me-ness* or from a bodily perspective, and Henry and Thompson press a similar point in direct engagement with Albahari (Zahavi 2005; Henry and Thompson 2011).

There is also a temporal version of the problem. A reportable episode must be located at least minimally in a before-and-after order. Windt makes this point for dreamless sleep by arguing that even putatively content-poor sleep experience involves a minimal temporality, such as duration or the sense of having been (Windt 2015). That temporal structure may be very thin. But if it is present, the state is not wholly bare subjectivity. If it is absent, then a retrospective report of the state cannot straightforwardly establish it as a first-person datum with no temporal structure.

Contentless-awareness reports still have evidential value. At most, though, they support the possibility of attenuated phenomenal character, reduced object-directedness, weakened self-representation, or unusual temporal and bodily structure. They do not establish bare metaphysical subjectivity as a datum. Indeed, the more a report says was absent during the episode (memory, selfhood, temporal grain), the more cautiously it must be used as first-person evidence. The ordinary conditions for accurate retrospective report are exactly what the report says were suspended. Schwitzgebel's general worries about introspective unreliability therefore compound the present restriction rather than replacing it (Schwitzgebel 2008, 2011).

The central dilemma remains. If pure awareness has some phenomenal character, even an attenuated character such as silence, openness, or bare temporality, then it is not characterless subjectivity. If it has no phenomenal character at all, then

it is not disclosed as experience in the way ordinary first-person evidence discloses pain or temporal flow. Either way, the appeal to pure awareness does not license the transfer from first-person acquaintance to a hidden ontology of bare fundamental consciousness. That conclusion was already in view from ordinary phenomenology and from the dilemma about characterless subjectivity; the strongest first-person challenge does not unsettle it.

5 The Failure of Warrant Transfer

The introspective warrant constraint becomes most important when panpsychism moves from ordinary consciousness to hidden phenomenal ontology. Contemporary panpsychist and panprotopsychist views may posit micro-experience, proto-experience, proto-phenomenal properties, cosmic subjectivity, hidden phenomenal fields, phenomenal bonding relations, or forms of phenomenal inheritance. These posits are not directly disclosed in ordinary first-person experience.

Such posits may be possible. They still cannot automatically inherit the epistemic privilege of first-person consciousness. The immediacy of pain warrants the pain, not a cosmic subject behind it; and the directness of visual experience warrants only that visual experience occurs, not that the microphysical entities involved in vision instantiate hidden phenomenal natures.

The warrant issue intersects the combination literature. Panpsychism's biggest internal puzzle is the combination problem: how do many small minds add up to one large mind? It is often treated as the question of how micro-experiences, micro-subjects, or proto-phenomenal bases could yield the macro-consciousness we know from our own case (Chalmers 2017; Coleman 2014; Roelofs 2019). But the very formulation already contains posits not delivered by the first-person datum: micro-subjects, micro-experiences, bonding relations, structural correspondences between micro- and macro-experience, or powers whose phenomenal nature grounds physical dispositions. If those posits solve the combination problem, they may be justified by that success. Such justification would be theoretical. It would not be the direct authority of first-person acquaintance carried downward or outward.

Mørch's phenomenal powers view is a particularly useful test case. On that view, phenomenal properties are not idle qualia but powers that can ground physical dispositions (Mørch 2020, forthcoming). If successful, this would give panpsychism a substantive explanatory role. But it also makes the present constraint sharper. First-person experience may acquaint us with phenomenal character, and perhaps with agency, motivation, or felt efficacy in ordinary cases. It does not follow that we are acquainted with fundamental phenomenal powers that ground the dispositional structure described by physics. That further claim needs theoretical support beyond the authority of acquaintance.

Panprotopsychism makes the warrant-transfer problem especially clear. The panprotopsychist need not say that fundamental entities are conscious. The claim is that they instantiate proto-phenomenal or proto-experiential properties that can help explain consciousness. But proto-experience is not something we encounter from

within. It is introduced as a theoretical posit. Its relation to ordinary consciousness must therefore be argued for, not assumed.

Here the panprotopsychist faces a dilemma. If proto-experience is sufficiently like experience, then it inherits familiar problems about structure, unity, subjecthood, and combination. If it is sufficiently unlike experience, then it loses its claim to first-person warrant. Either way, the appeal to ordinary consciousness does less work than advertised.

Phenomenal bonding faces the same limit. Goff's discussion of phenomenal bonding is explicitly designed to address the combination problem, the problem of how many micro-level subjects or phenomenal properties could yield one macro-level subject (Goff 2017b). That machinery may be part of a serious metaphysical theory. But it is not given in ordinary first-person experience. I am acquainted with pain, color, thought, and temporal flow. I am not acquainted, simply by being conscious, with relations by which micro-subjects combine into macro-subjects.

Panpsychism overdraws on first-person evidence when it treats the epistemic privilege of ordinary consciousness as support for a hidden phenomenal ontology. Those further posits may still be defended, but they must earn their warrant as theory rather than inherit it from acquaintance. At that point the panpsychist is doing what the functionalist and the materialist were already doing: observing the world, making inferences, and defending the result on the strength of those inferences. The first-person privilege that motivated the position originally no longer applies to the hidden posits it now wants to defend.

6 Structure and Dynamics Do Not Rescue the Inference

The Russellian monist can press a further argument. Physics, it is said, gives us only structure and dynamics. It describes relations, dispositions, equations, and causal roles. It leaves open the intrinsic or categorical nature of the entities that bear those roles. Consciousness, by contrast, is known from within. Perhaps consciousness reveals what matter is intrinsically, or at least gives us a model for what intrinsic nature could be (Goff 2017a).

This argument begins from a real limitation in structural description rather than a simple appeal to mystery. If a theory tells us only how entities are related or how they behave, one may ask what, if anything, has the structure or grounds the dispositions. The question is intelligible.

It is also clear why the panpsychist finds phenomenal filling tempting. If physics leaves categorical nature unspecified, and if consciousness is the one concrete reality whose nature seems available from the inside, then consciousness appears to be the only available model of intrinsic nature. The move is not arbitrary. It is an attempt to use the one apparent case of acquaintance to illuminate what structural physics leaves dark.

But the step from vacancy to phenomenal filling is not licensed by first-person experience alone. From the claim that matter has an unknown intrinsic nature, it does not follow that this intrinsic nature is experiential or proto-experiential. First-person

experience discloses ordinary consciousness. It does not disclose the intrinsic nature of electrons, fields, spacetime, or the cosmos. Nor does it disclose ordinary consciousness as fundamental categorical nature. That is the point at issue. Consciousness may be intrinsic, derivative, emergent, organizational, or something else. Acquaintance with experience does not settle which of these metaphysical readings is correct. To identify categorical physical nature with phenomenal or proto-phenomenal nature is therefore a metaphysical inference.

Russellian monism survives this point. A Russellian panpsychist may have further arguments. The claim may be defended by appeal to simplicity, explanatory gap considerations, anti-emergentist premises, or a broader theory of categorical properties. But once the argument takes that form, it is no longer simply an appeal to first-person immediacy. It is a theoretical proposal about what best fills an explanatory or metaphysical gap.

First-person evidence has unusual authority only within its proper domain. I can be directly aware of my pain. I cannot be directly aware, by that same act, that the intrinsic nature of all matter is pain-like, experience-like, or proto-phenomenal. The structure/dynamics argument may explain why a panpsychist looks for something beyond structural physics. It does not show that the thing found must be consciousness. At most, consciousness supplies a candidate model for intrinsic nature. The suitability of that model must be defended by the theory, since first-person acquaintance supplies the experience itself rather than its fundamental metaphysical role.

7 Goff, Strawson, and Degrees of Strain

The introspective warrant problem applies with different force to different panpsychist views: austere realistic monism, micropsychism, cosmopsychism, panprotopsychism, and phenomenal-powers grounding each face it differently. Some views lean directly on first-person evidence for the posits they introduce. Some are already operating as abductive metaphysical theories but retain the rhetorical glow of first-person privilege. Some make no first-person warrant claim at all, in which case the constraint does not apply to them. A fair criticism should not treat every version of panpsychism as if it made the same claim.

Strawson's realistic monism is the austere baseline. Strawson argues that experience is real, that experience is physical if physicalism is true, and that the emergence of experience from the wholly non-experiential would be unintelligible (Strawson 2006). This argument does not depend on recognizably human-like particle minds. It is a serious attempt to force physicalism to include experience within the physical.

Strawson may be right that experience is part of reality and cannot be dismissed. First-person acquaintance with ordinary experience still does not warrant the stronger claim that experientiality exists at the fundamental level. The introspective warrant constraint permits the datum of experience. It does not permit an automatic inference from that datum to microphysical experientiality.

Goff's more elaborate Russellian and cosmopsychist machinery makes the problem sharper. His work develops panpsychism within a structure/dynamics framework

and addresses the combination problem through proposals such as phenomenal bonding and cosmopsychism (Goff 2017a,b, 2019). Cosmopsychism is especially important because it reverses the micropsychist direction. Instead of beginning with many micro-subjects and trying to combine them into human subjects, it begins with a cosmic subject and attempts to derive local subjects from it.

This may avoid some versions of the combination problem. But it worsens the introspective warrant problem. Cosmic subjectivity is hidden from third-person science and unlike anything first-person experience discloses. Ordinary first-person experience reveals local, finite, perspectival consciousness with determinate phenomenal character. It does not reveal a unified cosmic experiencer from which local minds derive.

That claim should not be read as assuming that cosmopsychism faces a simple mirror image of micropsychism's combination problem. Shani explicitly resists that framing and argues that cosmopsychic individuation need not be understood as the reverse of micropsychist subject-summing (Shani 2015, 2022). Albahari and Mørch likewise explore versions of cosmic or universal consciousness that complicate simple charges about decombination and unity (Albahari 2019; Mørch 2024). The present point is narrower. Even if these views offer a coherent theory of cosmic individuation, the cosmic subject is not disclosed in ordinary first-person acquaintance. Its warrant is therefore holistic, metaphysical, or explanatory, not directly first-personal.

Goff's more recent hybrid cosmopsychism also changes the target. He now treats subjects as strongly emergent while phenomenal properties are weakly emergent, in part to explain how panpsychism is supposed to help with consciousness without inheriting the worst forms of subject-combination difficulty (Goff 2024). This refinement concedes strong emergence at the level of subjects, which is precisely where much of the original anti-emergentist pressure was supposed to bite. Goff's view may still be defensible. The concession matters because the anti-emergentist appeal can no longer carry the full first-person motivation for panpsychism by itself. Once panpsychism explains ordinary subjecthood through emergence, grounding, and top-down structure, it is operating as a theoretical metaphysics. It cannot simply retain the immediacy of the original first-person datum for the full hidden ontology it introduces.

Other sophisticated responses differ in detail. Mørch's phenomenal powers view tries to make phenomenal properties do causal and grounding work, and Roelofs's composite-subject strategy tries to resist the inference from the apparent privacy of subjects to the impossibility of mental combination (Mørch 2020; Roelofs 2019). These are constructive theories, with machinery meant to do more than carry first-person consciousness down to the particle level. Roelofs in particular can say that constitutive panpsychism need not predict introspective access to micro-properties. The micro-properties constitute what is introspected, but they need not themselves appear as objects of introspection. That reply may protect the theory from a simple phenomenological objection, while sharpening the present point. Once the micro-level is not introspectively disclosed, first-person evidence no longer warrants it directly. The constitutive claim must then be defended by its theoretical role in explaining the macro-consciousness that is disclosed.

Appeals to phenomenal acquaintance face the same limit. Suppose, with the panpsychist, that acquaintance with experience gives us some unusually intimate grasp of the nature of experience. Even then, acquaintance reaches only the experience with which one is acquainted. It does not by itself acquaint us with micro-experiences, proto-phenomenal categorical bases, cosmic subjectivity, or the relations by which local subjects might derive from a wider subject. The appeal to acquaintance may therefore support claims about ordinary experience. It does not automatically extend to the hidden phenomenal architecture introduced to make panpsychism work.

The more panpsychism elaborates the machinery needed to solve its internal problems, the farther it moves from the first-person datum that gave it plausibility. The machinery may still be true, but once it is detached from the immediacy of acquaintance it has to be defended on the same theoretical footing as any other metaphysical hypothesis.

8 Explanatory Burden

Treating panpsychist posits as theoretical rather than first-personal shifts the burden. Micro-experience, proto-experience, or cosmic subjectivity may be possible. The harder question is what these posits explain. Once first-person warrant is no longer doing the paying, the hidden phenomenal base has to earn its keep through explanatory work.

An adequate theory of consciousness should help explain its unity, its contents, its temporal grain, its sensitivity to factors such as sleep and anesthesia, the difference between processes that enter experience and those that do not, and why experience has valence. Panpsychism need not explain all of these features by its fundamental phenomenal base alone. A panpsychist can reasonably say that attention, memory, reportability, temporal integration, and many contents depend on organization. That concession is important. It locates the pressure point more precisely.

Once organization is doing the work of explaining the structure of ordinary consciousness, the question is what explanatory work remains for the hidden phenomenal base. If its main role is to block brute emergence from the wholly non-phenomenal, that may be a serious metaphysical role. But it is not the same as explaining the determinate structure of the consciousness we actually undergo. The panpsychist therefore owes an account of what the hidden base does, beyond standing in the place where brute emergence would otherwise stand. Otherwise the posit only records the discomfort with brute emergence, without yet explaining the organized consciousness that motivated the discomfort.

This point supplies no complete emergentist theory of consciousness. I am not deriving phenomenality from organization, nor claiming to solve the hard problem. The question remains why any organized processing should feel like anything at all. Panpsychism relocates that difficulty into the relation between fundamental phenomenal or proto-phenomenal properties and the determinate consciousness we actually undergo. Unless those hidden properties explain enough to justify their theoretical cost, the abductive burden remains in place.

Papineau’s treatment of the explanatory gap and phenomenal concepts presses a nearby concern. Papineau argues that the felt gap between physical and phenomenal description may arise from how we think about conscious states, not from the need to posit extra non-physical ontology (Papineau 2002). The present argument is not identical to Papineau’s physicalism. It does, however, share a pressure point: before adding hidden phenomenal properties to reality, we should ask what explanatory work they perform beyond marking our resistance to brute emergence.

A panpsychist may reply that this burden is not unique. Mendelovici argues that the combination problem resembles structural problems faced by many theories of consciousness, including problems of phenomenal unity, mental structure, and new quality spaces (Mendelovici 2019). Saad offers a different abductive route, arguing that psychophysical harmony can support panpsychism independently of the first-person route criticized here (Saad 2022). I grant both points. Physicalism also owes an account of why organization gives rise to experience, unless it denies or deflates the explanandum. The present argument is not that panpsychism alone faces all structural burdens, nor that no independent abductive argument is possible. Panpsychist arguments that make no claim on first-person warrant, of which Saad’s harmony argument is the cleanest case, are outside the present argument’s reach, not within its target. The introspective warrant constraint is a discipline on how first-person evidence is used; it has nothing to say about views that do not use it. The argument here is that first-person evidence cannot by itself pay the cost of the hidden phenomenal base. Where panpsychism is defended by harmony, phenomenal powers, cosmopsychic individuation, or composite subjectivity, its warrant is theoretical and should be evaluated as such.

Dreamless sleep is a useful conceptual illustration, provided it is handled carefully. Dreamless sleep does not prove that consciousness is absent. A panpsychist, a Buddhist philosopher, or a theorist of minimal consciousness may argue that some form of experience occurs without later memory. The modest point is that such a claim requires independent warrant. If there is no memory, no report, no phenomenological trace, and no distinctive explanatory payoff, then first-person evidence does not license the posit.

Temporal grain illustrates the same pattern. Human consciousness appears to have thresholds and integration windows. Some stimuli may be processed without entering experience at all, and conscious episodes seem to depend on temporally organized uptake rather than on every event in the nervous system surfacing as experience. A panpsychist can say, consistently, that sub-threshold processes still have micro-experiential aspects. But that reply does not yet explain why ordinary consciousness has the temporal boundaries it has, why some processed information enters experience while other information does not, or why integration at one scale yields a conscious episode while nearby subpersonal processing remains outside awareness. If hidden experientiality is placed beneath the threshold, the question is what it explains about the threshold. Without such an account, the posit multiplies hidden phenomenal facts beneath temporal structure rather than explaining that structure.

These examples are conceptual illustrations rather than empirical proofs against panpsychism. They illustrate the warrant problem. Panpsychism repeatedly posits

experience or experience-like properties where experience itself gives no clear warrant. That may be permissible as theory. It is not directly licensed by the first-person datum.

Worries about introspection itself strengthen this restriction. Schwitzgebel argues that introspection may be unreliable even in ordinary cases where we might expect it to be secure (Schwitzgebel 2008, 2011). This worry compounds rather than competes with the present argument. If introspection is fallible even within its proper domain, then the case for restricting its reach is overdetermined. It should be extended beyond ordinary experience to hidden micro-, proto-, or cosmic phenomenal ontology only with special caution.

9 Conclusion: The Limits of Special Warrant

Panpsychism survives this argument; what does not survive is the way panpsychism leans on first-person experience for warrant. First-person experience tells us that there is consciousness, and tells us something about what conscious life is like. That is real evidence, and the paper does not minimize it. What it does not tell us is that consciousness is fundamental, microphysical, cosmic, or proto-phenomenal.

Consciousness is real. Panpsychism's further phenomenal posits need a different warrant; they are not paid for by the same first-person evidence that pays for the reality of consciousness. They may still be defended, but only as theory, and only by explaining enough to justify their cost. The methodological point is that knowing consciousness from within does not by itself settle its metaphysical status.

The paper therefore gives a constraint rather than a disproof. Panpsychism may appeal to independent metaphysical arguments, anti-emergentist principles, simplicity considerations, psychophysical harmony, or Russellian claims about intrinsic nature. Those arguments may succeed or fail on their merits. What they may not do is borrow the authority of ordinary first-person consciousness and spend it on entities or structures that ordinary first-person consciousness never reveals. Whether the version on offer is austere realistic monism, micropsychism, cosmopsychism, panprotopsychism, or phenomenal-powers grounding, it must compete with its rivals on the same abductive terms as any other metaphysical hypothesis.

This conclusion does not vindicate illusionism or deflationary physicalism. Those views face their own burden, since denying or deflating the first-person datum carries a substantial cost. The present argument is narrower. Any view that takes first-person consciousness seriously must also respect the limits of what first-person consciousness discloses.

Panpsychism overdraws on experience when it treats the epistemic privilege of ordinary consciousness as support for a hidden phenomenal ontology. The broader pattern is a temptation to move too quickly from phenomenology to fundamental metaphysics. Panpsychism is the central case considered here, but the corrective is more general.

First-person experience gives panpsychism a datum, not a license for the metaphysics built on top of it.

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